

What else to watch: *The Defiant Ones* (1958) ■ *À bout de souffle* (1960, pp.166–67) ■ *Easy Rider* (1969, pp.196–97) ■ *Badlands* (1973) ■ *Taxi Driver* (1976, pp.234–39) ■ *True Romance* (1993) ■ *Natural Born Killers* (1994)



Bonnie (Faye Dunaway), Clyde (Warren Beatty), and even Clyde's brother Buck (Gene Hackman) see how the papers sensationalize the facts and exaggerate the crimes.

At first, Clyde laughs off the attention, and he and Bonnie take playful, gun-toting photos of themselves for the press, playing along with the media game and enjoying their celebrity. But as the law closes in, and the pair's

situation becomes increasingly desperate, the barrage of lies told about them in the newspapers begins to wear Clyde down, most noticeably when an article falsely accuses him of robbing the Grand Prairie National Bank—which enrages him so much that he promises to actually do it.

The relentless attention of the media ultimately robs the two thieves of their sense of self,

Bonnie and Clyde pose for a photo with their hostage, Captain Frank Hamer (Denver Pyle). In real life, Hamer did not meet either of them until the day his posse killed them.

leaving them powerless to present their true selves to the world. Only as the movie nears its bloody end are they given a reprieve of sorts, when a short, charming poem Bonnie has written, telling of her pride in knowing a decent man like Clyde, is published in a newspaper. Their side of the story is told, just once.

Like other movies of the time, *Bonnie and Clyde* makes it hard for the viewer not to root for its amoral protagonists, sympathizing more with their media manipulation than the victims of their robberies. ■

“They’ll go down together / They’ll bury them side by side / To a few, it’ll be grief / To the law, a relief / But it’s death for Bonnie and Clyde.”

Bonnie Parker / The Ballad of Bonnie and Clyde